

BULLYING RESPONSE PROTOCOL

How we prevent, report, investigate, and repair bullying, together.



• WHY THIS MATTERS

SAFETY IS NOT NEGOTIABLE

Every student at Wendell Phillips has the right to learn in a place where they feel safe. Bullying is not a normal part of growing up, and it is not “kids being kids.” When it happens, how the adults respond decides whether a child feels protected or feels alone.

This protocol is our shared, consistent way to respond. It protects the student who was harmed first, it takes every report seriously, and it makes sure no single adult has to carry it alone.

If you raise a concern in good faith, that will never be held against you. You do not have to be certain it is bullying to report it. Your job is to notice and tell someone. The process below takes it from there.

• DEFINITION

WHAT COUNTS AS BULLYING

Bullying is repeated behavior that involves a real or perceived power imbalance and is meant to hurt, control, or humiliate another student. **Three things usually show up together:** it repeats or is likely to repeat, one student holds more power (size, status, numbers, or information), and it is intended to cause harm.

THE FORMS IT CAN TAKE

FORM	LOOKS LIKE
Physical	Hitting, pushing, tripping, or taking and breaking belongings.
Verbal	Name-calling, threats, or cruel, repeated teasing.
Social or relational	Deliberate exclusion, spreading rumors, or turning a group against someone.
Cyber	Hurtful messages, images, or posts, including off campus when they carry into school.

WHAT IS NOT BULLYING — BUT STILL GETS A RESPONSE

A one-time conflict, a mutual argument, or two students who both had a part in a disagreement is usually conflict, not bullying. Conflict still matters and still gets a response, but it moves down the restorative and Tier 1 path, not this one.

Mislabeling cuts both ways. Calling real bullying “just conflict” leaves a child unprotected. Calling ordinary conflict “bullying” can label a child unfairly.

THE PROTOCOL AT A GLANCE

When bullying is suspected or reported:

- 1 **Keep everyone safe.** Separate the students and make sure the target is okay before anything else.
- 2 **Report the same day** to the leadership team, the Director of Culture, the restorative team, and the counselors.
- 3 **A counselor interviews the target** using the Bullying Report Form.
- 4 **The form goes to the Assistant Deans.**
- 5 **The Deans interview witnesses and the alleged aggressor**, then decide next steps and consequences.
- 6 **The Deans contact the families** of both students.
- 7 **The final decision goes back to the team**, and restorative repair and follow-up begin.

WHO DOES WHAT

ROLE	THEIR PART IN THIS PROTOCOL
Teacher or staff who receives the report	Keep students safe. Write down what you saw or were told, in facts, not conclusions. Report the same day. Do not investigate, question the group, or confront the alleged aggressor yourself.
School Counselors Kern K-4 · Flores 5-8	Interview the target with care, using the Bullying Report Form. Support the student's emotional safety first, then capture an accurate account. Pass the completed form to the Assistant Deans.
Restorative Team	Lead repair when appropriate, support re-entry, and keep both students connected to the community. Restorative work supports the process; it does not replace consequences in confirmed bullying.
Assistant Deans / Administrators	Interview witnesses and the alleged aggressor. Determine whether it meets the bullying definition. Decide consequences. Communicate with both families. Share the final decision with the team.
Director of Culture & Leadership Team	Receive every report, protect the timeliness and integrity of the process, track patterns across the school, and make sure follow-up actually happens.

THE FULL SEQUENCE

STEP 1 · KEEP EVERYONE SAFE

IMMEDIATELY

Separate the students. Make sure the target is physically and emotionally okay. Do not question students about the incident in front of their peers. Get another adult to cover if you need to.

STEP 2 · REPORT THE SAME DAY

Get a Bullying Report Form. Copies are kept with the counselors, the restorative team, teachers, the front office, and Mr. O's office.

Notify the leadership team, the Director of Culture, the restorative team, and the counselors. Report what you directly saw or were told, in facts ("Jordan said Sam pushed him twice and took his lunch"), not conclusions ("Sam is a bully").

STEP 3 · A COUNSELOR INTERVIEWS THE TARGET

A counselor meets privately and gently with the student who was harmed, and records the account on the Bullying Report Form. The counselor's first job is the student's safety and emotional wellbeing, then an accurate record.

STEP 4 · THE FORM GOES TO THE ASSISTANT DEANS

The completed Bullying Report Form is handed to the Assistant Deans, who own the investigation from this point.

STEP 5 · THE DEANS INTERVIEW WITNESSES AND THE ALLEGED AGGRESSOR

The Assistant Deans gather the other accounts: any witnesses first, then the alleged aggressor. They keep an open mind and stay with the facts.

STEP 6 · DETERMINE AND DECIDE

The Assistant Deans, **in collaboration with the Director of Culture**, decide whether the incident meets the bullying definition and set consequences. Consequences are progressive and restorative-informed: they hold the student accountable and teach a different choice. They are not punishment alone.

STEP 7 · COMMUNICATE WITH FAMILIES

The **Assistant Principal or the Director of Culture** contacts both families — which one depends on the student's tier. The target's family hears what happened and how we are keeping their child safe. The aggressor's family hears what happened and the next steps.

STEP 8 · THE FINAL DECISION GOES BACK TO THE TEAM

The **Campus Administrator** shares the final determination with the counselors, restorative team, Director of Culture, and leadership, so everyone supporting these students knows the outcome and the plan.

STEP 9 · REPAIR AND RE-ENTRY

When appropriate, the restorative team leads repair and supports the aggressor's re-entry, and keeps supporting the target. **In confirmed bullying, repair happens in addition to consequences, not instead of them.**

STEP 10 · FOLLOW UP AND WATCH FOR RETALIATION

Someone on the team checks back with the target to make sure it stopped, and watches for retaliation. Retaliation against anyone who reported or took part is treated as a new and serious incident.

● TIMELINES

RECOMMENDED TIMEFRAMES

STEP	TARGET TIMEFRAME
Report of a suspected incident	Same school day
Counselor interviews the target	Within 24 hours of receiving the report
Deans interview witnesses and the alleged aggressor	Within 24 hours of receiving the report
Family communication	Within 24 hours of receiving the report
Follow-up check-ins with the target	At 1 week and 2 weeks

DOCUMENTATION AND CONFIDENTIALITY

The Bullying Report Form is the official record for each case. **Copies are kept with the counselors, the restorative team, teachers, the front office, and Mr. O's office.**

Share details on a need-to-know basis, with the adults directly supporting the students. We protect student privacy and follow FERPA.

We stay honest about what we can and cannot promise. **We cannot promise a report will stay completely private**, because keeping a child safe sometimes means involving others. We can promise it will be handled with care and shared only with the people who need to act on it.

REPORTING IN GOOD FAITH IS PROTECTED

Anyone — a student, a family member, or a staff member — can report a concern. A good-faith report will never be held against the person who made it, even if it turns out not to be bullying. Retaliation against a reporter, a target, or a witness is itself a violation of this protocol.

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QUESTIONS? **ASK.**

This is a living document. If a step does not work in practice, tell the Director of Culture so we can fix it. Edge cases and "is this actually

a Level 2?" calls go to the counselors or to me — that is what we are here for, and asking is never an imposition.

M. Williams

Director of Student Support & School Culture

Matchbook Learning at Wendell Phillips School 63 · K-8

SAFE. RESPECTFUL. RESPONSIBLE.